

John Wilkes

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John Wilkes was a very interesting and complicated man, a radical and a libertine, who had a major influence on the governance of Britain for many years. He was a radical journalist, politician, magistrate, essayist, and soldier. He was said to be the ugliest man in Britain due to a protruding jaw and an unsightly squint, though his great charm offset this.

John Wilkes is remembered chiefly for the Middlesex election dispute of 1769, in which he fought for the rights of electors, rather than the House of Commons, to choose their representatives, for asserting the right of newspapers to report the proceedings of Parliament, and for his support of the American colonists in the American War of Independence.

He was born in Clerkenwell in 1725. His father was a distiller. He went to Leiden University in Holland, where he became sympathetic to religious non-conformists and developed a strong sense of patriotism. At the age of 22, he made an advantageous marriage to Mary Meade, then aged 32, and came into possession of an estate and income in Buckinghamshire. They separated after ten years; Wilkes never married again, but gained a reputation as a rake.

He was a Fellow of the Royal Society from 1749, appointed High Sheriff of Buckinghamshire in 1754 and elected MP for Aylesbury in 1757 and 1761. He was also a member of the notorious Hellfire Club in West Wycombe.

Wilkes first came to prominence when the Earl of Bute became head of the government in 1762, and Wilkes started the radical publication *The North Briton* to attack him. In issue 45 of April 1763, Wilkes strongly attacked King George III's speech, said to have been written by Bute. A general warrant was used to arrest Wilkes and 49 others. Wilkes successfully argued that he was protected by parliamentary privilege. Parliament then removed that



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protection in cases of seditious libel.

Also in 1763, a pornographic poem, *Essay on Women*, partly written by Wilkes, was used by his enemies to attack him. One was the Earl of Sandwich, who told Wilkes, "Sir, I do not know whether you will die on the scaffold or of the pox." Wilkes replied, "That depends, my lord, on whether I embrace your lordship's principles or your mistress." After the poem was declared obscene and blasphemous in the House of Lords, Wilkes fled to Paris, where he was tried in absentia, found guilty and declared an outlaw.

He returned to England in 1768. The government delayed arresting him, fearing popular unrest.

He stood again as MP for Middlesex in 1768, waived his immunity, and was sentenced to two years' imprisonment and a £1,000 fine. After he entered the King's Bench Prison in Southwark, his supporters gathered in St George's Fields chanting "No liberty, no King". Troops opened fire, causing deaths and injuries. Wilkes was expelled from Parliament four times and re-elected each time by the Middlesex voters, but Parliament declared his opponent the winner. Wilkes then mobilized his supporters to elect him as an Alderman of the City of London.

Wilkes was released from prison in March 1770 and resumed his seat as an MP. He condemned Government policy towards the American colonies and introduced the first Radical bill to Parliament, though it failed. His greatest success was helping to secure the freedom of the press by ending the use of general warrants and Parliament's power to punish reports of its debates.

During the Gordon Riots of 1780, he commanded the militia protecting the Bank of England. On his orders, troops fired into the mob. His popularity rapidly declined, although he remained MP for Middlesex until 1790.

He died in January 1797. A talking statue to his memory stands in Fetter Lane, off Fleet Street.